

managers in the meeting to write down three things about sales training they'd like to see added or changed. Then the managers exchanged sheets and added three more ideas. "After a few rounds of this, they'd forgotten their jobs and titles and were busy scribbling. Each round triggered new ideas."

Johnson understands how important it is to know your audience. In meetings she tries to identify nonverbal signals, to stay in control of the situation, and to be sensitive to listeners' needs (which must be met before they'll actually hear and absorb what's being said). She also tries to slow down nonstop talkers, stimulate quiet participants, and draw out information using various types of questions. "My personal style is to be natural and extemporaneous," says Johnson. "My agenda, visuals, and notes help me achieve that tone."

Johnson's new position puts her at the head of a department charged with smoothing human relations. Keeping everyone happy at a company with thousands of employees is no easy task. So more than ever, Johnson will be relying on her listening and speaking skills to meet that challenge.¹ ■

Did You Know?

Nonverbal cues provide 93 percent of the meaning exchanged in any interaction: 35 percent from tone, and 58 percent from gestures, expressions, and other physical cues.

Nonverbal communication is more reliable and more efficient than verbal communication.

People use nonverbal signals to support and clarify verbal communication.

The face and eyes command particular attention as a source of nonverbal messages.

UNDERSTANDING THE IMPORTANCE OF NONVERBAL COMMUNICATION

Virginia Johnson tries to identify nonverbal signs during her meetings because she knows that the old maxim is true: People's actions often do speak louder than their words. In fact, most people can deceive others much more easily with words than they can with their bodies. Words are relatively easy to control; body language, facial expressions, and vocal characteristics are not. By paying attention to these nonverbal cues, you can detect deception or affirm a speaker's honesty.

Because nonverbal communication is so reliable, people generally have more faith in nonverbal cues than they do in verbal messages. If a person says one thing but transmits a conflicting message nonverbally, listeners almost invariably believe the nonverbal signal.² Remember, the meaning of nonverbal communication lies with the observer, who both reads specific signals and interprets them in context of a particular situation and a particular culture. Chances are, if you can read other people's nonverbal messages correctly, you can interpret their underlying attitudes and intentions and respond appropriately.

Nonverbal communication is important for another reason: It can be efficient from both the sender's and the receiver's standpoint. You can transmit a nonverbal message without even thinking about it, and your audience can register the meaning unconsciously. At the same time, when you have a conscious purpose, you can often achieve it more economically with a gesture than you can with words. A wave of the hand, a pat on the back, a wink—all are streamlined expressions of thought. Although nonverbal communication can stand alone, it usually blends with speech, carrying part of the message. Together, the two modes of expression are a powerful combination, augmenting, reinforcing, and clarifying each other.

The Types of Nonverbal Communication

According to one estimate, there are more than 700,000 forms of nonverbal communication.³ For discussion purposes, however, these forms can be grouped into the following general categories:

- *Facial expressions and eye behavior.* Your face is the primary site for expressing your emotions; it reveals both the type and the intensity of your feelings.⁴ Your eyes are

especially effective for indicating attention and interest, influencing others, regulating interaction, and establishing dominance. In fact, eye contact is so important in the United States that even when your words send a positive message, averting your gaze can lead your audience to perceive a negative one.⁵ Although the eyes and the face are usually a reliable source of meaning, people sometimes manipulate their expressions to simulate an emotion they do not feel or to mask their true feelings. As Chapter 3 will explain, maintaining eye contact is not important in some cultures. In fact, it can be considered impolite.

- **Gestures and postures.** By moving your body, you can express both specific and general messages, some voluntary and some involuntary. Many gestures—a wave of the hand, for example—have a specific and intentional meaning, such as “hello” or “good-bye.” Other types of body movement are unintentional and express a more general message. Slouching, leaning forward, fidgeting, and walking briskly are all unconscious signals that reveal whether you feel confident or nervous, friendly or hostile, assertive or passive, powerful or powerless.
- **Vocal characteristics.** Like body language, your voice carries both intentional and unintentional messages. On a conscious level, we can use our voices to create various impressions. Consider the sentence “What have you been up to?” If you repeat that question four or five times, changing your tone of voice and stressing various words, you can convey quite different messages. However, your vocal characteristics also reveal many things that you are unaware of. The tone and volume of your voice, your accent and speaking pace, and all the little *um*’s and *ah*’s that creep into your speech say a lot about who you are, your relationship with the audience, and the emotions underlying your words.
- **Personal appearance.** Your appearance helps establish your social identity. People respond to others on the basis of their physical appearance. Because you see yourself as others see you, these expectations are often a self-fulfilling prophecy. When people think you’re capable and attractive, you feel good about yourself, and that feeling affects your behavior, which in turn affects other people’s perceptions of you. Although an individual’s body type and facial features impose limitations, most people are able to control their attractiveness to some degree. Grooming, clothing, accessories, “style”—all modify a person’s appearance. If your goal is to make a good impression, adopt the style of the people you want to impress.
- **Touching behavior.** Touch is an important vehicle for conveying warmth, comfort, and reassurance. Even the most casual contact can create positive feelings. This fact was revealed by an experiment in which librarians alternately touched and avoided the hands of students while returning their library cards. Although the contact lasted only half a second, the students who had been touched reported far more positive feelings about themselves and the library, even though many of them didn’t even remember being touched.⁶ Perhaps because it implies intimacy, touching behavior is governed in various circumstances by relatively strict customs that establish who can touch whom and how. The accepted norms vary, depending on the gender, age, relative status, and cultural background of the persons involved. In business situations, touching suggests dominance, so a higher-status person is more likely to touch a lower-status person than the other way around. Touching has become controversial, however, because it can sometimes be interpreted as sexual harassment.

Body language and tone of voice reveal a lot about a person’s emotions and attitudes.

DID YOU KNOW?

In Turkey, it’s considered rude to cross your arms while facing someone.

Physical appearance and personal style contribute to one’s identity.

Your use of touch, your attitude toward time, and your use of space (all of which are affected by culture) help establish your social relationships.



COMMUNICATING ACROSS CULTURES

ACTIONS SPEAK LOUDER THAN WORDS ALL AROUND THE WORLD

"He wouldn't look me in the eye. I found it disconcerting that he kept looking all over the room but rarely at me," said Barbara Walters after her interview with Libya's Colonel Muammar el-Qaddafi. Like many people in the United States, Walters was associating eye contact with trustworthiness, so when Qaddafi withheld eye contact, she felt uncomfortable. In fact, Qaddafi was paying Walters a compliment. In Libya, *not* looking conveys respect, and looking straight at a woman is considered nearly as serious as physical assault.

Nonverbal communication varies widely between cultures, even between subcultures, and the differences strongly affect communication in the workplace. Whether you're trying to communicate with your new Asian American assistant, the Swedish managers who recently bought out your company, the young African American college student who won a summer internship with your firm, or representatives from the French company you hope will buy your firm's new designs, your efforts will depend as much on physical cues as on verbal ones. Most Americans aren't usually aware of their own nonverbal behavior, so they have trouble understanding the body language of people from other cultures. The list of differences is endless:

- In Thailand it's rude to place your arm over the back of a chair in which another person is sitting.
- Finnish female students are horrified by Arab girls who want to walk hand in hand with them.
- Canadian listeners nod to signal agreement.
- Japanese listeners nod to indicate only that they have understood.
- British listeners stare at the speaker, blinking their eyes to indicate understanding.

- People in the United States are taught that it's impolite to stare.
- Saudis accept foreigners in Western business attire but are offended by tight-fitting clothing and by short sleeves.
- Spaniards indicate a receptive friendly handshake by clasping the other person's forearm to form a double handshake.
- Canadians consider touching any part of the arm above the hand intrusive, except in intimate relationships.

It may take years to adjust your nonverbal communication to other cultures, but many options can help you prepare. Books and seminars on cultural differences are readily available, as are motion pictures showing a wide range of cultures. You can always rent videos of films and TV shows from other countries. Examining the illustrations in news and business magazines can give you an idea of expected business dress and personal space. Finally, remaining flexible and interacting with people from other cultures who are visiting or living in your country will go a long way toward lowering the barriers presented by nonverbal communication.

1. Explain how watching a movie from another country might help you prepare to correctly interpret nonverbal behavior from that culture.
2. One of your co-workers is originally from Saudi Arabia. You like him, and the two of you work well together. However, he stands so close when you speak with him that it makes you very uncomfortable. Do you tell him of your discomfort, or do you try to cover it up?

- *Use of time and space.* Like touch, time and space can be used to assert authority. Some people demonstrate their importance by making other people wait; others show respect by being on time. People can also assert their status by occupying the best space. In U.S. companies, the chief executive usually has the corner office and the prettiest view. Apart from serving as a symbol of status, space can determine how comfortable people feel talking with each other. When others stand too close or too far away, you are likely to feel ill at ease. However, as Chapter 3 will point out, attitudes toward punctuality and comfort zones vary from culture to culture.

How to Improve Your Nonverbal Communication Skills

To improve your nonverbal communication skills, pay more attention to the kinds of signals just discussed. It is particularly important to avoid giving others conflicting signals. For instance, if you tell an employee that you are free to talk to about her raise but your nonverbal signals suggest that this is not the best time to discuss the subject, she will be confused. So try to be as honest as possible in communicating your emotions. Here are some additional tips for honing your nonverbal skills:⁷

- Smile genuinely. A fake smile is obvious because the timing isn't right and the wrinkles don't follow.
- Be aware that people may give false nonverbal cues.
- Keep appropriate distance and use touch only when appropriate.
- Respect status with your eye contact.
- Adopt a handshake that matches your personality and intention.

Remember, few gestures convey meaning in and of themselves; they have to be interpreted in clusters, and they should reinforce your words.

IMPROVING YOUR ORAL COMMUNICATION SKILLS

Virginia Johnson's job at 3M may involve more oral communication than many jobs do, but her experience is by no means unusual. Speaking and listening are the communication skills people use most. Given a choice, people would rather talk to each other than write to each other. Talking takes less time and needs no composing, keyboarding, rewriting, duplicating, or distributing.

More important, oral communication provides the opportunity for feedback. When people communicate orally, they can ask questions and test their understanding of the message; they can share ideas and work together to solve problems. Talking things over helps

You can improve nonverbal skills by paying more attention to cues, both yours and those of others.

Oral communication saves time and provides opportunities for feedback and social interaction.



This speaker uses gestures and facial expressions to emphasize important points and reveal her attitude toward topics.